

92% excellent bathing water

*A public claim, tested against EEA season data
A dated result is not a current trend.*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

***“92% of Maltese bathing waters are
of excellent quality.”***

European Commission, Environmental Implementation Review 2025
The percentage matches 80 of 87 sites in the EEA's 2023 season data.

VERDICT: SUPPORTED

Accurate for 2023; date it.

TL;DR

The European Commission’s 2025 Malta review says **92% of Maltese bathing waters were excellent**. That percentage matches the EEA’s 2023 season result: 80 of 87 sites. It is accurate for that reference year, but the Commission’s highlight does not state the year. The latest available EEA result when this check was prepared was 77 of 87 sites (88.5%) in 2025.

- 1

The 92% figure checks out. The EEA classified 80 of 87 Maltese bathing sites as excellent in 2023: 92.0%.
- 2

It is not the latest season. In 2024, 80/87 were excellent; in 2025, 77/87 (88.5%) were excellent.
- 3

‘Excellent’ is a specific indicator. The classification uses E. coli and intestinal enterococci. It is not a general measure of marine ecosystem or chemical health.
- 4

Local pollution can coexist with the national result. Balluta Bay sites B08/B09 had a temporary health warning in 2024. This local episode does not change the 2023 national percentage.
- 5

Verdict: supported, with a date caveat. The Commission’s wording is accurate for 2023; it should not be presented as Malta’s current result.

THIS CLAIM

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

92.0%

Excellent in 2023 (80/87 sites)

92.0%

Excellent in 2024 (80/87 sites)

88.5%

Excellent in 2025 (77/87 sites)

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

None: Supported is the top of the scale. Only the date caveat remains; it would fall away if the Commission’s text named the 2023 season beside the 92% figure.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

A different EEA count for 2023; a source showing that the Commission meant a later season (the 2025 result was 88.5%); or evidence that its percentage used an incompatible denominator.

IN THIS REPORT

1 Claim and sources

2 What the indicator measures

3 Season results

4 Local pollution and wastewater

5 Verdict and limits

1

Claim and sources

The Commission’s *Environmental Implementation Review 2025: Malta* states: “Malta also shows excellent records under the Bathing Water Directive: 92% of Maltese bathing waters are of excellent quality.” The sentence appears in the report’s highlights. It does not name a reference year beside the percentage. The EEA data show that 92% corresponds to the 2023 season.

Source	What it establishes	Use
European Commission, EIR 2025: Malta	Exact 92% sentence; separate discussion of wastewater treatment.	Claim wording
EEA, Malta bathing-water profiles, 2023–2025	Annual classifications, site counts and sampling figures.	Primary statistical series
Environmental Health Directorate, Balluta Bay report (2024)	Temporary warning at sites B08/B09 and when it was lifted.	Local context
CJEU, Commission v Malta, C-304/23 (2024)	Urban wastewater treatment obligations for named agglomerations.	Separate compliance issue

FAIRNESS NOTE

Short-term pollution warnings and wastewater-treatment problems matter to public health and environmental management. They do not, by themselves, disprove a national multi-season bathing-water classification for a particular year. This check assesses the dated statistic, not whether every beach is always clean or whether Malta’s marine environment is healthy overall.

2

What the indicator measures

Under the Bathing Water Directive, classification is based on measured concentrations of two faecal-indicator bacteria: *Escherichia coli* and intestinal enterococci. The EEA’s country profile reports site classifications and samples. “Excellent” is a meaningful result for those parameters and the directive’s monitoring framework; it does not cover every pollutant, every day, or all dimensions of marine ecological and chemical status.

The directive’s classification is not a guarantee that no short-lived contamination event occurs. A site can receive a temporary warning and still be included in a national multi-year classification. The timeframe and denominator should accompany the percentage when it is repeated.

3

What the season data show

Bathing season	Excellent	Other classifications	Sites	Samples
2023	80 (92.0%)	3 good; 4 sufficient	87	2,021
2024	80 (92.0%)	3 good; 4 sufficient	87	2,107
2025	77 (88.5%)	8 good; 2 sufficient	87	2,100

READING THE SERIES

The 2023 and 2024 excellent shares were both 92%. The 2025 share was 88.5%. All 87 sites in 2025 were classified at least sufficient; none was classified poor or left unclassified. The 2025 result is the latest annual profile available for this check.

4

Local pollution and wastewater

The Environmental Health Directorate’s Balluta Bay report records a temporary warning and closure at sites B08 and B09 beginning in late May 2024. The report describes microbial contamination and foul water from a storm-water tunnel. The warning was lifted on 12 August after three consecutive samples fell below the relevant thresholds. This was a serious local event over a defined period; it does not alter the count of sites classified excellent for 2023.

In Case C-304/23, the Court of Justice found failures to comply with urban wastewater treatment obligations for named agglomerations. That judgment is not a bathing-water classification, and it does not show that the EEA’s 2023 result was false. The Commission’s own review reports both bathing-water quality and wastewater-treatment concerns under separate headings.

5

Verdict and limits

SUPPORTED · HIGH CONFIDENCE

The EEA’s 2023 figures confirm 80 excellent sites out of 87, which rounds to the Commission’s 92%. The figure is accurate for 2023. The 2025 result is 88.5%, so the year should be stated whenever the 92% figure is used as a description of Malta’s bathing-water quality.

This verdict covers only the quoted 2023 statistic. The EEA classification uses data reported by Malta; this check is not an independent resampling programme. It does not assess chemical pollutants, marine ecological status, or health outcomes beyond the directive’s microbiological classification.

Right of reply has not been sought, as directed by the maintainer. The report remains a draft for maintainer review.

References

- European Commission, *Environmental Implementation Review 2025: Malta*. Exact claim wording and separate wastewater discussion.
- European Environment Agency, Malta bathing-water profiles for seasons 2023, 2024 and 2025. Site classifications, sample counts and parameters. The 2023 sample count is from the EEA’s WISE Bathing Water Directive dataset (DiscoData, retrieved 5 October 2026; data/cc-005/).
- Environmental Health Directorate, *Report on the temporary closure at B08 and B09 Balluta Bay* (2024).
- Court of Justice of the European Union, *Commission v Malta*, Case C-304/23, ECLI:EU:C:2024:906 (17 October 2024).

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply not sought, at the maintainer's direction.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Corrections: (1) the 'what would move the verdict' boxes were reversed. 'Up' listed conditions that would lower the verdict, and 'down' cited a newer season at 92% or more. Now: up, none (Supported is the top of the scale; naming the 2023 season would remove the date caveat); down, a different 2023 count, a later intended season or an incompatible denominator. (2) Balluta Bay warning start: '31 May 2024' → 'late May 2024'. Our bibliography gave 21 May, and news reports date the two sites' warnings ten days apart; the primary report could not be re-opened to settle it. (3) 2023 sample count: '—' → 2,021 (EEA WISE dataset). (4) Page footer: 'pending right of reply' → 'right of reply not sought', matching the maintainer's decision. Verdict and confidence unchanged.